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A Christmas Carol

A Radio Play

By

PHILIP GRECIAN

Based upon the novel by

CHARLES DICKENS



Dramatic Publishing Company
Woodstock, Illinois ● Australia ● New Zealand ● South Africa

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For the Air Command company members,
who make worlds, stories and people
out of the air and on the air.

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PRODUCTION NOTES

A staged radio drama is often more economical than full-stage productions, but there are several things to consider before going into rehearsal:

1. Everything depends on sound. Never cast an actor because of his or her physical presence. Cast the actor because of what he or she can do vocally. Many of the actors from the golden age of radio looked not at all the way they sounded.

2. Don't worry about costuming your actors to look like the characters they play. That's not the point. If you must have costuming, concentrate on the fashions of the 1940s, when radio was in its golden age, or costume your cast and musicians in cocktail dresses and tuxedos. Sometimes, perhaps, the addition of a hat may help the actor to get into character. A prop may be necessary or even a cigar or pipe or glasses.

3. Remind your actors that the voice must carry it all. In the final evaluation, everything is in the voice.

4. Try to cast actors who can do multiple voices and accents. Onsite audiences are fascinated to watch a single actor play multiple characters, though it's usually best not to have a single actor's characters in conversations with each other.

5. Music is terrifically important. It sets mood, moves your story from one location or time frame to another and gives your audience clues regarding how they are supposed to relate to a scene. It is like the score in a film. We use a single keyboard in our productions, sometimes with an organ sound, sometimes with a piano sound. We have also used a violin for some scenes and an autoharp for transitions between times and/or space.

6. The real visual drama for the onsite audience is in watching the sound effects crew. Make sure they, and their various apparatuses, are clearly seen.

7. Try never to use prerecorded sound. It robs the audience of the experience of seeing how a sound is produced.

8. A pause in radio drama is eternal. Though you are staging this drama, the audience is "seeing" it in their minds' eyes, and a pause that is too long may throw them out of the story. Always keep energy high. Always.

9. Some actors are more comfortable when they can make eye contact with those with whom they are acting. In staging, whenever possible, keep two characters in a conversation close to each other, without another actor between them.

10. In the commercial breaks written into the script, consider actually selling commercial time to local merchants and dramatizing commercials written specifically for your production. It helps with the production budget, and audiences love it.

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A Christmas Carol was first produced and broadcast by The Air Command at KTWU-TV, Topeka, Kansas, on Nov. 23, 2012, with multiple rebroadcasts through the month of December. It was directed by Philip Grecian with the following company:

Storyteller / Ebenezer Scrooge.....Philip Grecian
Male Player 1, Bob Cratchit, Partygoer 2, Passerby.....Shawn Trimble
Male Player 2, Fred, Jacob Marley,
Businessman on the Street, Passing Brother.....Jay Hurst
Charity Woman, Fiddler, Lady With Packages,
Martha, Partygoer 3, Widow Krook.....Sarah May Shaffer
Female Player 2, Charity Woman, Belle,
Belinda Cratchit, Partygoer 1, Mrs. Dilber.....Chelsey Shirrell
Female Player 3, Ghost of Christmas Past, Fred's Wife.....Cortni Hurst
Fan, Tiny Tim, Partygoer 6, Boy on the Street.....Karly Hanna
Male Player 5, Fezziwig, Man With Packages,
Topper, Businessman on the Street, Whitlow.....Les Smith
Male Player 3, Dick Wilkins, Peter Cratchit, Partygoer 4, Passerby 2.....Dustin Dean
Male Player 4, Ghost of Christmas Present, Businessman on the Street, Old Joe.....David Tangeman
Female Player 1, Mrs. Cratchit, Partygoer 5.....Kirsten Goodman

Stage Manager & Booth.....Denise Butterfield
Assistant Stage Manager & Booth.....Roger McCauley
Music Director/Keyboard.....Skip Ellis
Assistant to the Music Director.....Diane Ellis
Violin and Autoharp.....Sarah May Shaffer
Sound Effects.....Steffen Wong, Stacey Smith, Andrew Entsminger, Arlyn Brunken
Costumes.....Arlyn Brunken
Sound Effects Constructions.....Larry Grecian

For KTWU
CEO/General Manager.....Eugene Williams
Executive Producer.....Val VanDerSluis
Producers.....Val VanDerSluis, Jim Kelly
Directors.....Lloyd Slapar, Jim Kelly
Promotion.....Kevin Goodman

Recorded in the Olive White Garvey Studio Complex on the campus of Washburn University.

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A Christmas Carol

CHARACTERS

P.A. VOICE
ANNOUNCER
STORYTELLER / EBENEZER SCROOGE
FEMALE PLAYER 1-4
MALE PLAYER 1-5
FRED / MALE PLAYER 2
BOB CRATCHIT / MALE PLAYER 1
CHARITY WOMAN 1, 2
JACOB MARLEY
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST
FAN
FEZZIWIG
DICK WILKINS
FIDDLER
BELLE
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT
MAN AND LADY (with packages)
MRS. CRATCHIT
PETER CRATCHIT
BELINDA CRATCHIT
MARTHA CRATCHIT
TINY TIM
TOPPER
FRED'S WIFE
PARTYGOER 1-6
BUSINESSMAN 1, 2, 3 (on the street)
PASSERBY 1, 2
MRS. DILBER
OLD JOE
WIDOW KROOK
WHITLOW
PASSING BROTHER
BOY (on the street)

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A Christmas Carol

ACT I

SETTING: *A radio studio. A door upstage with an "On Air" light above. A platform L where the keyboard player sits. R is an array of sound effects machines and tables with sound equipment. There is a couch and a coffee table UC and a counter area UR with water pitchers and cups. Chairs and incidental tables are scattered around the stage. DC are three microphones evenly spaced. The light plot is simple: a general wash for the beginning and end of Act I and the beginning of Act II, the ability to independently dim the lights upstage and downstage, and the ability to spot each of the microphones, the keyboard and the sound effects.*

AT RISE: *The sound effects crew enters and crosses to their equipment. Music director enters. Actors enter one at a time and in groups, some carrying scripts.*

P.A. VOICE. Thirty seconds to air!

ALL *(ad-lib)*. Thank you!

(The actors, ad-libbing, prepare. Some leaf through their scripts. Some pick up scripts from chairs and tables. Others sit or move to microphones.)

P.A. VOICE. In 10 …

(The pace quickens as those actors on microphones find places in their scripts and listen for the P.A. VOICE or watch the "On Air" light on the set.)

P.A. VOICE *(cont'd)*. Five … four … three … two … one …

(The "On Air" light comes on.)

ANNOUNCER. Broadcasting from the _____ radio studios, _____ presents theatre of the mind … Charles Dickens' *A Christmas Carol*, a radio dramatization written by Philip Grecian and based on the novella by Charles Dickens. In a moment, our story, but first, these words …

(MUSIC: Theme segue to commercial break.

Commercials here.

MUSIC: Theme up and under.)

ANNOUNCER *(cont'd)*. Now fill your cup with hot buttered rum, call the family together and move in close to the warm glow of your radio dial to hear *A Christmas Carol*—the story of Ebenezer Scrooge.

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(MUSIC: Theme, up, establish and under.

A group of actors sing "Deck the Halls" up and under, off mic.)

STORYTELLER. Ah … hear that? A kind of music that comes around once a year. Always makes me feel good. A Christmas song. Well … more than that. A Christmas *carol*. A part of Christmas … a part of you. For as long as you can remember. Like an old, old friend.

(MUSIC: Fades.)

FEMALE PLAYER 1 *(moves to STORYTELLER's microphone).* Well, that's one kind of Christmas carol, but we're here to present another kind; one written by Charles Dickens in 1843. It takes place in London, England, and it's the story of mean old Ebenezer Scrooge. Shall we tell a story, then?

(The cast ad-libs agreement.

MUSIC: Intro up and under.)

FEMALE PLAYER 1 *(cont'd, thinks a moment. Inspiration).* All right then, let's see, how shall we begin? Well … Marley was dead, to begin with. There is no doubt whatever about that. Old Marley was dead as a doornail.

MALE PLAYER 1. A doornail?

FEMALE PLAYER 1. Yes. Odd, isn't it? But that's what Mr. Dickens said, "As dead as a doornail."

(STORYTELLER takes FEMALE PLAYER 1's mic.)

MALE PLAYER 2. I don't know what's particularly dead about a doornail, but that is what Marley was as dead as … and Marley was dead. Therefore …

MALE PLAYER 1. … a doornail.

MALE PLAYER 2. A doornail.

(FEMALE PLAYER 2 takes MALE PLAYER 2's mic.)

MALE PLAYER 1. But a doornail's not dead in the first place.

STORYTELLER. Neither was Marley … in the first place.

MALE PLAYER 1. Oh. *(He moves away from the mic, upstage.)*

STORYTELLER. But finally—in the second place—he was.

(MUSIC: Punch.)

STORYTELLER *(cont'd)*. Now, you must understand that Marley was quite dead, or else nothing wonderful can come from the story we're about to tell.

FEMALE PLAYER 2. I think we all understand that. But tell us about Scrooge!

STORYTELLER. Shush now, we're getting to Scrooge. Scrooge and Marley had been partners in business before Marley died, and they called their business establishment …

FEMALE PLAYER 2. Scrooge and Marley!

STORYTELLER *(mildly annoyed)*. Strangely enough, yes. Scrooge never painted out old Marley's name on the sign. There it stood, for years, "Scrooge and Marley." Sometimes people called Scrooge "Scrooge," sometimes "Marley." He answered to both. It was all the same to him. The only change over the years was that he'd had Marley's desk moved out because …

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FEMALE PLAYER 2. … Marley was dead.

(MUSIC: Punch.)

STORYTELLER. Quite
FEMALE PLAYER 2. As a doornail.

(MUSIC: Punch.

FEMALE PLAYER 2 exits, and MALE PLAYER 3 takes her mic.)

STORYTELLER. Yes. They had been partners for I don't know how many years. Scrooge was Marley's only friend …
MALE PLAYER 3. … and Marley was Scrooge's only friend …
STORYTELLER. Because no one else could tolerate either of them. Between the two, there wasn't an ounce of heart, not a tuppence of compassion. Why, when Marley died, Scrooge didn't even close the shop. Do you know why?
MALE PLAYER 3. He said it would be bad business.
STORYTELLER. Exactly
MALE PLAYER 3. But tell us about Scrooge!

(MUSIC: Dark, foreboding, establish and under.)

STORYTELLER. Oh, he was a tight-fisted old skinflint! A squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous old sinner! Hard and sharp as flint! His heart was colder than a snowman!
MALE PLAYER 3. That is cold!

(MALE PLAYER 3 steps away from the mic. MALE PLAYER 1 takes his place.)

STORYTELLER. Yes it is. He carried the cold within him always. It made his hair the color of snow after the wagons had passed. It froze his old features, nipped his nose, shriveled his cheeks, stiffened his gait, made his eyes red, his lips thin and cruel and blue and frostbitten!

(STORYTELLER's voice changes as he turns into SCROOGE. Raspy and mean, and—if he didn't have one before—he begins to acquire a British accent.)

STORYTELLER *(cont'd)*. And it spoke out through him in his cold … icy … grating … voice. And he never thawed even one degree. Not. Even. At. Christmas. Christmas! Humbug! Now tell the story and be quick about it.

(STORYTELLER, now SCROOGE, moves away from the mic.

The cast ad-libs: "Tell the story," "Who's gonna do it," etc. Quickly, FEMALE PLAYER 3 steps up to the mic.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3. Once upon a time …

(The cast ad-libs groans.)

MALE PLAYER 1. Do they always have to start out, "Once upon a time … "?

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FEMALE PLAYER 3 *(trying to come up with another opening line)*. Mmmm. How about, "We were somewhere around Barstow on the edge of the desert … "

CAST. No!

FEMALE PLAYER 3. "Last night I dreamt I went to Manderley again."

CAST. No!

FEMALE PLAYER 3. "Whether I shall turn out to be the hero of my own life … "

CAST. No!

FEMALE PLAYER 3. "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times … "

CAST. No!

FEMALE PLAYER 3. Well then, you shall have to be satisfied with, "Once upon a time." That's what Mr. Dickens wrote, and I don't think we should tamper.

(The cast complains, ad-libbing under their collective breath while acknowledging that it is too late to change it now.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3 *(cont'd)*. So …

(MUSIC: Up and under.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3 *(cont'd)*. Once upon a time … on Christmas Eve—old Scrooge sat busy in his counting house … It was cold, bleak, biting weather, and he could hear the people in the court outside, go wheezing up and down, beating their hands upon their breasts, and stamping their feet upon the pavement stones to warm them.

MALE PLAYER 1. The old grandfather's clock in Scrooge's office struck three …

(SFX: Clock chimes three.)

MALE PLAYER 1 *(cont'd)*. … and, though it was only mid-afternoon, it was dark and foggy outside. It had been that way all day. Scrooge's clerk, Bob Cratchit, sat at his desk, copying letters. *(Acquires BOB CRATCHIT's dialect as he speaks.)* He wore a long white scarf to keep out the bitter cold, for Scrooge was too stingy to keep a warm fire blazing at the hearth.

MALE PLAYER 2. And on this particular Christmas Eve, Scrooge had a visitor. It was his nephew, Fred, *(Acquires FRED's dialect.)* who entered the establishment all in a glow …

(SFX: Door opens. The cold wind.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. … his eyes sparkling, and the spirit of Christmas radiating from his wind-burned face.

(Now in character as FRED.)

FRED. A merry Christmas, Uncle!

(SFX: Door closes. Wind stops.)

SCROOGE. Bah! Humbug!

FRED. Christmas a humbug, Uncle! You don't mean that!

SCROOGE. I do mean it! What reason have you to be so merry? You're poor enough!

FRED. What reason have you to be so angry? You're rich enough!

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SCROOGE. Bah! Humbug!

FRED. Don't be cross, Uncle!

SCROOGE. What else can I be in such a world of fools! Merry Christmas indeed! What is Christmas but a time for paying bills without money, for finding yourself a year older and not an hour richer? Every idiot who goes about with "Merry Christmas" on his lips should be boiled in his own pudding, and buried with a stake of holly through his heart! Oh, that's good! "Stake of holly!" *(Laughs.)*

FRED *(mock surprise and shock)*. Uncle!

SCROOGE. Nephew! Keep Christmas in your own way, and let me keep it in mine!

FRED. But you don't keep Christmas in any way.

SCROOGE. Let me leave it alone then! It is best left alone!

FRED. On the contrary, Christmas is a good time. A time when men and women open their hearts freely! A time of love and the spirit of giving! And though it has never put a scrap of gold or silver in my pocket, I believe that it *has* done me good …

SCROOGE. Humbug!

FRED. … and will do me good …

SCROOGE. Humbug!!

FRED. … and I say God bless it!

CRATCHIT. God bless it!

SCROOGE. Another sound from you, Cratchit, and you'll spend your Christmas looking for another position!

CRATCHIT. Yes, sir. Sorry, sir.

FRED. Come, don't be angry, Uncle. Dine with us tomorrow!

SCROOGE. No.

FRED. My wife is preparing a Christmas dinner that a king would envy.

SCROOGE. I am not a king.

FRED. Mother thought you were.

SCROOGE. My sister is dead! And it … it is a charity that she is … so that she cannot see what a worthless rogue her son has become.

FRED. You know better than that.

SCROOGE. I tell you, Fan is dead! Every year you come storming into my office, trailing in bushels of snow … disrupt my day and babble about Christmas and how wonderful it is … and every year you invite me to Christmas dinner!

FRED. And every year you turn me down.

SCROOGE. Exactly!

FRED. And every year you say, *(Imitating SCROOGE.)* Humbug!

SCROOGE. And I say it again: Humbug! If you know what I will say before I say it, why do you bother to come here every year to hear me say it?

FRED. Because, Uncle, one of these times … one of these Christmases … you will accept my invitation.

SCROOGE. Humbug! Get out! Good afternoon!

FRED. Uncle, it's Christmas!

SCROOGE. Good afternoon!

FRED. I'm sorry for you. But, Merry Christmas all the same, Uncle!

SCROOGE. Good afternoon!

FRED. And a happy New Year!

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SCROOGE. I said good af-ter-*noon!*

FRED. Good afternoon.

(SFX: Door opens. Wind sound up.)

FRED. Merry Christmas, Bob!

CRATCHIT. Merry Christmas, sir.

(SFX: Door closes. Wind stops.)

SCROOGE. Cratchit!

CRATCHIT. Oh! Yes, sir. Sorry, Mr. Scrooge.

SCROOGE *(to himself)*. Merry Christmas, indeed … and there's Cratchit wishing him the same, and he hasn't but 15 shillings a week to his name. Mad as hatters! Every one of 'em. Mad as hatters.

(SFX: Door opens. Wind.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Hm. Who's this now? More fools. Whole world of fools. Well … I'll confuse 'em. *(Laughs dryly.)*

(SFX: Door closes. Wind stops.)

CHARITY WOMAN 1. This is Scrooge and Marley's establishment, I believe?

SCROOGE. It is.

CHARITY WOMAN 2. Have we the pleasure of addressing Mr. Scrooge or Mr. Marley?

SCROOGE. If I were Mr. Marley, I would not have answered when you spoke just now.

CHARITY WOMAN 2. He is deaf?

SCROOGE. He is dead. He died seven years ago this very night … and he is still dead.

CHARITY WOMAN 1. Then you would be Mr. Scrooge.

SCROOGE. How proud your mother must be of your discerning nature. Now, out with it! What is it you want?

CHARITY WOMAN 2. It is Christmas, Mr. Scrooge …

SCROOGE. I am aware of it, thank you. No one will let me forget it!

CHARITY WOMAN 2. … and during Christmas, our organization …

CHARITY WOMAN 1. … a charitable one …

CHARITY WOMAN 2. … sees to it, through donations from men such as yourself, that the poor are not forgotten.

SCROOGE. Forgotten! How could I ever forget them! I pay taxes to support the workhouses for them … they pass me on the streets every day! Every other fool seems to be concerned with their well-being and talks incessantly about their plight! How could I ever forget them!

CHARITY WOMAN 1 *(unsure)*. Exactly.

SCROOGE. I am reminded every day that the poor need this, the poor need that! Put them in prison where they belong if they haven't money to pay their debts! At least there they would have a free meal! Are there no prisons?

CHARITY WOMAN 2. Plenty of prisons.

SCROOGE. And the workhouses! They can go to the workhouses … put in 15 hours a day at hard labor! Oh, but wait, is it possible … Are the workhouses still in operation?

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CHARITY WOMAN 1. I wish I could say that they were not.

SCROOGE. Those who work there are fed, are they not?

CHARITY WOMAN 2. They eat gruel.

SCROOGE. Good! If they want better food, they can go find better jobs. I did!

CHARITY WOMAN 1. Mr. Scrooge …

SCROOGE. And I am glad to hear that the workhouses are still in operation. I was afraid that something had occurred to stop them.

CHARITY WOMAN 2. We are trying to raise money to buy the poor some meat and drink to celebrate Christmas. How much would you wish to give?

SCROOGE. Nothing.

CHARITY WOMAN 2. Nothing?

SCROOGE. I wish to give nothing! I wish to be left alone! I do not make merry myself at Christmas, and I cannot afford to make idle people merry! I pay taxes to support the prisons and workhouses! Let the poor go to them!

CHARITY WOMAN 1. Many can't go there; and many would rather die.

SCROOGE. Yes, I know. So then, they had better do it and reduce the surplus population!

CHARITY WOMAN 1. But … but …

SCROOGE. Good afternoon!

CHARITY WOMAN 2. Well … I … G-g-good afternoon, Mr. Scrooge.

CHARITY WOMAN 1. Afternoon, Mr. Scrooge … Merry … um … happy … I …

(SFX: Door opens. Wind comes up. Door closes, killing wind.

MUSIC: In and under to fade.)

FEMALE PLAYER 2 *(no dialect)*. Meanwhile the fog and darkness thickened. The cold became intense. But the Christmas spirit warmed the people of London town.

FEMALE PLAYER 4. One young fellow stood outside Scrooge's door, and in the hope of a mug of hot chocolate, entered and serenaded him with a Christmas carol.

(FEMALE PLAYER 4 begins the first few words of "God Rest Ye, Merry Gentlemen," now with a dialect.

SFX: Wind under song. Door opens.)

SCROOGE. Get away! Get from my door, you young roughneck!

(FEMALE PLAYER 4 stops and exits.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Away with you! God rest ye merry gentlemen, indeed! Of all the …

(SFX: Door slams, stopping wind. Clock strikes five.)

CRATCHIT. Good night, Mr. Scrooge.

SCROOGE. Where do you think you're going, Cratchit?

CRATCHIT. Home, sir.

SCROOGE. You've finished your work, then?

CRATCHIT. Yes, sir.

SCROOGE. All of it?

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CRATCHIT. Yes, sir.

SCROOGE. And you will want to stay home all day tomorrow, I suppose?

CRATCHIT. Yes, sir. If it's quite convenient, sir.

SCROOGE. It is *not* quite convenient!

CRATCHIT. But tomorrow's Christmas, sir.

SCROOGE. Humbug! It is not fair!

CRATCHIT. It's only once a year, sir.

SCROOGE. Only once a year, sir! You only pick my pocket once a year! You only waste a whole working day once a year! You get no other day off all year, why should you get Christmas?

CRATCHIT. But, sir …

SCROOGE. Go on, take tomorrow off then!

CRATCHIT. Oh, thank you, sir!

SCROOGE. But be here early the next day!

CRATCHIT. Yes, sir! Very well, sir!

(SFX: Scuffling around and under.)

CRATCHIT *(cont'd)*. Thank you, sir! Merry Christmas, Mr. Scrooge!

(SFX: Door opens. Wind up. Door slams, stopping wind.)

SCROOGE. Humbug!

(MUSIC: Under narration.)

MALE PLAYER 1. And so Scrooge closed up his office …

(SFX: Slam door. Lock door. Footsteps along cobblestones.)

MALE PLAYER 1 (cont'd). … and went home to a gloomy suite of rooms on the upper floor of an unhappy old building in an unhappy old neighborhood. Its yard was so dark that even Scrooge, who knew every stone, had to grope his way to the foot of the wooden stairs rising up along the outside wall.

(SFX: Climbing wooden steps, continue under.)

MALE PLAYER 1 *(cont'd)*. And this Christmas Eve, like every Christmas Eve before, he mumbled angrily to himself as he climbed the steps to his front door.

(MUSIC: Fade out.)

SCROOGE. Christmas! Bah, humbug! "Merry Christmas, Uncle," he says! An idiot! A Christmas pudding-head! Hm! Much good it's ever done him! "Happy New Year," he says! And what is new about the new year? Same as the old year! Miserable! And Bob Cratchit with 15 shillings a week and a wife and family to support talking about a merry Christmas!

MALE PLAYER 4. It was very late and very dark now, and Scrooge, who took this trip every evening, could barely see as he climbed to his front door.

SCROOGE. "We are trying to raise money to buy the poor some meat and drink to celebrate Christmas." Hmf! What do they have to celebrate? They're poor, aren't they? "God rest ye merry gentlemen … " Humbug!

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(SFX: Steps stop.

MUSIC: Continues under narration.)

MALE PLAYER 4. … but, finally, he did reach the top … and then began searching his pockets for the key.

(SFX: Large ring of old keys.)

MALE PLAYER 4 *(cont'd)*. Now, there was nothing at all particular about the knocker on Scrooge's door. He had seen it, night and morning, during his whole residence in the apartment.

MALE PLAYER 2. Nor was Scrooge a man of great imagination, and he had not thought much about the dead Jacob Marley in seven years. But as he found his key and turned, the knocker on the door began to move … changed …

(MUSIC: Eerie, transformational.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. … and became the face of …

SCROOGE. Jacob Marley!

(MUSIC: Sting and under.)

MALE PLAYER 2. As clearly as Scrooge had seen him in life!

SCROOGE. No! You're dead! Marley is dead!

MALE PLAYER 2. Scrooge's blood ran cold, and he stood a moment, facing away from the dreaded door. Finally, he was brave enough to turn and look … and Marley's face was gone. Scrooge stood facing his own door. And it was … only his door, and nothing else. The door he had seen thousands of times before.

(MUSIC: Fade out.)

SCROOGE. Hmph! Never happened. Imagined it. Only … shadows. Marley is dead. Humbug!

(SFX: Latch click, door opens. Pause. Door closes hard. Latch clicks.)

MALE PLAYER 2. Scrooge locked himself in.

(SFX: Lock turns and clicks.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. With a double lock.

(SFX: Lock clicks again.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. And thus secured against surprise, he changed into his dressing gown, slippers and nightcap, and sat down close to the fire to eat his gruel.

(SFX: Fire in a fireplace. Spoon in gruel against bowl as he eats, and under.)

SCROOGE. Merry Christmas! Humbug! Marley's face on the door. More humbug!

(MUSIC: Low, eerie, sustained notes and under.

The cast moans lightly, quietly off mic.)

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SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Seeing things that aren't there. Marley's dead! Been dead for seven years. Dead men don't …

(SFX: Chains rattling, then stop. Spoon in bowl sound stops.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. What was that?

(SFX: Chains rattling and echoing off mic, then stop.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. There it is again! Who is it? Who's there? *(Pause.)* Bah! The wind!

MARLEY *(whispers)*. Ebenezer Scrooge!

(MUSIC: Up, frantic, eerie.

Each cast member whispers, "Ebenezer Scrooge," in turn. This continues under SCROOGE's following line.)

SCROOGE. Who is it? Who's there? Who calls me? Let me see you! Where are you hiding? You won't frighten me! *(He's frightened.)* How did you get in? Where are you? Show yourself! Stop it! Stop it!

(MUSIC: Stops.

The cast stops.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. It's stopped. Of course it has. Wind in the chimney flue … that's all. Wind in the …

MARLEY *(breathless, echoed)*. Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE. Who are you? Why do you call me? Show yourself!

(MUSIC: Rising minor scale, followed by eerie minor cords under all that follows.

SFX: JACOB MARLEY's chains rattle.

NOTE: Echo voice and chains throughout.)

MARLEY. I am here, Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE. Jacob Marley! Jacob Marley! But … I … but, you … you're … dead!

MARLEY. I am.

SCROOGE. Then you … you must be …

MARLEY. I am.

SCROOGE. What do you want with me?

MARLEY. Much.

SCROOGE. This can't be Marley. Who are you? Tell me who you are.

MARLEY. Ask me who I *was*.

SCROOGE. Who were you, then?

MARLEY. In life, I was your partner, Jacob Marley.

SCROOGE. It *is* Marley! No … no … I'm imagining this. I've gone … mad … mad with all this infernal Merry Christmas!

MARLEY. You don't believe in me.

SCROOGE. No.

MARLEY. You doubt your own senses?

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SCROOGE. I may be dreaming you. You … you might be a nightmare brought on by eating too much. You might be a crumb of spoilt cheese or an underdone potato. You may not have risen from your grave, but from my gravy!

(MARLEY raises a terrible wailing.

MUSIC: Up, sudden, violent.

SFX: Violent shaking of chains.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Please, Jacob, why do you trouble me?

(SFX: Chains stop shaking but remain under the scene, rattling with MARLEY's every move.

MUSIC: Under all.)

MARLEY**.** Do you believe, then?

SCROOGE. I must. I must. But why are you here?

MARLEY. It is my curse.

SCROOGE. You're cursed, Jacob?

MARLEY. I have been cursed to wander through the world and witness what I cannot share … to witness the unhappiness I caused in life … unhappiness I cannot change in death … *(He howls and moans.)*

(SFX: Chains.

SCROOGE howls and moans as well, and for a time, they moan together.)

SCROOGE. Why do you moan? Are you in pain?

(SFX: Chains stop.)

MARLEY. I grieve. I grieve over the chain I wear.

SCROOGE. Why do you wear it?

MARLEY. Because it is my own. Because I forged it in life. I made it myself, link by link and yard by yard. Each link a sin committed in life.

(SFX: Chain sounds match the action indicated by the dialog. The chains punctuate everything MARLEY says, every movement we hear him make.)

MARLEY *(cont'd)*. Look. Here. With this link I turned my back on a man who asked for my help …

SCROOGE. Yes. I see it. But I …

MARLEY. And this one. I cheated a friend out of what was his.

SCROOGE. Tell me …

MARLEY. And this … thievery … this … greed … then apathy, sloth, malice, revenge, disloyalty, selfishness, cowardice! Link upon link, I forged the chain in life I now bear in death. We pay for our sins, Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE. It is quite a long chain, Jacob.

MARLEY. Yours is longer.

SCROOGE. My chain?

MARLEY. The chain you will wear in the afterlife. It grows longer each day.

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SCROOGE. No …

MARLEY. I can do nothing for you, Ebenezer Scrooge. You have made your own chain. You have added new links every hour.

SCROOGE. No, no, please, Jacob! Tell me it isn't so!

MARLEY. I cannot. Only you have the power to change yourself, Ebenezer Scrooge. And you have much to make up for. I have sat, invisible, beside you many a day since my death.

SCROOGE. What an unpleasant thought, Jacob. But you died seven years ago; why have you not gone to your reward?

MARLEY *(another moan)*. A weary journey lies before me, Ebenezer Scrooge. I must roam through eternity … I cannot rest. I may not sleep. There is no peace for Jacob Marley.

SCROOGE. It is your curse.

MARLEY. It is.

SCROOGE. But you were always a good man … of business … Jacob.

MARLEY. Business!

(MUSIC: Punctuates, "Business!" Then under.)

MARLEY *(cont'd)*. Mankind was my business. The common welfare was my business; charity, mercy, forbearance, benevolence … these were all my business. Or should have been!

SCROOGE. Well, but Jacob, you …

MARLEY. Hear me!

(MUSIC: Crash of chords.

SFX: Chains rattle angrily.)

SCROOGE *(startled)*. Oh!

MARLEY. I am here to provide a warning. You have yet a chance to escape my fate!

SCROOGE. You were always a good friend to me. Thank you, Jacob, thank you.

MARLEY. You will be haunted …

SCROOGE. Haunted!

MARLEY. By three spirits.

SCROOGE. I thank you very much, Jacob, for the offer, but I think I'd rather not …

MARLEY. You must! For without their visits, you cannot hope to shun the path I tread. Expect the first on Christmas morning when the bell tolls one.

SCROOGE. But … but I …

MARLEY. Expect the second on the following night at the same hour.

SCROOGE. Could I take them all at once and have it done with, Jacob?

MARLEY. The third will come on the final night at the stroke of midnight.

SCROOGE. Couldn't they just write letters or …

MARLEY. And now I must go, Ebenezer Scrooge, to join the other lost souls on our long journey.

SCROOGE. Go? Go where?

MARLEY. Out there …

(SFX: Window flies open. Wind. Multiple rattling chains.)

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SCROOGE. Out the window! But, Jacob, we're up so high! You'll fall … you'll …
MARLEY *(moving away from the mic)*. And up … up … *(He wails.)*

(MUSIC: Crashing chords under moaning, then a slow fade.

SFX: Wind continues.)

SCROOGE *(calling)*. Jacob! Jacob! I can't see you! Jacob! Jacob! Jacob! Wait! Wait!

(SFX: The wailing and rattling chains begin to fade under SCROOGE's dialog. Only the wind remains.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Don't leave me, Jacob! Please, Jacob! Don't … Gone. All … gone. Oh. My. Cold. Brrr. Close the …

(SFX: Closes window. Wind stops. Latch click.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. There. Better. Warmer now. He just … went up … straight up … just … *(Pause.)* No. Never … never there, most likely. Imagined it. *(He grunts.)* Never happened. Humbug! Never happened! Well. Well that's settled then.

(SFX: Shuffling slippers.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Off to bed now. Off to bed.

(SFX: Door opens.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Off to bed.

(SFX: Door closes lightly.)

MALE PLAYER 2. … And so Scrooge slipped into his bed, drew the curtains and slept.

(MUSIC: Extended bridge and under. Time passes.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. Until, when the hour bell sounded …

(SFX: Clock strikes one.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. … light flashed up in the room … his bed curtains were drawn back, and …

(SFX: Curtains on wooden rings, drawn quickly on a wooden pole.

MUSIC: Sting and end.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Ebenezer Scrooge!
SCROOGE *(fear in his voice)*. You're the spirit … the one that Jacob Marley said would come.
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. I am.
SCROOGE. Who … who and what are you?
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. I am the Ghost of Christmas Past.
SCROOGE. Long past?
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Your past.
SCROOGE. Are you a child?

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GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Do I seem a child?

SCROOGE. Yes. Well … a moment ago you did … but now … now you seem as old as I. Or even … older. You … change.

(MUSIC: Under narrative, fading before SCROOGE's line.)

MALE PLAYER 2. Indeed, the spirit's hair was white, yet its face had not a wrinkle in it, lending it an air of ancient wisdom and youthful hope.

FEMALE PLAYER 3. It wore a tunic of the purest white and held a branch of fresh green holly in its hand, while its dress was trimmed in summer flowers.

MALE PLAYER 2. … And from the crown of its head there burned a bright, clear flame, while it held under its arm a large pointed hat, shaped like a candle snuffer.

SCROOGE. You are so bright! Would you please be so good as to put on your cap and extinguish your glow?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. What? Would you put out the light I give?

SCROOGE. Oh … well … Why are you here?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Rise from your bed and walk with me.

SCROOGE. Very well …

(SFX: Throwing back of covers, creak of bed springs.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Let me put on my slippers. I …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Come.

SCROOGE. Outside?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. At first.

(SFX: Slippers slide along on floor.)

SCROOGE. It's quite cold outside.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. My light will warm and protect you.

(SFX: Window opens. Wind up and under.)

SCROOGE. Out the window? I'll fall.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. I will protect you from it.

SCROOGE. Will it be a long walk?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Very long.

SCROOGE. Into the country?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Into your past.

SCROOGE. But I …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Take my hand. Have faith. And leap.

SCROOGE. But I don't think I … *(Whoops as his voice fades.)*

(SFX: Wind comes up, stronger and louder. Window slams shut, killing the wind sound.

MUSIC: Harp gliss up with wind, then under, fades as keyboard comes up under.

SFX: SCROOGE's footsteps, echoing under the dialog.

NOTE: Very slight echo on all voices and SFX in this empty school.)

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GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Do you know this place?

SCROOGE. I do. It's the school I attended as a boy.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. How many Christmases did you spend here?

SCROOGE. Too many.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. How many years did you sit at your desk in this schoolroom … a solitary child neglected by friends and family.

SCROOGE. My father … never cared where I spent my Christmas.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. But there was one, Ebenezer. One who loved you … and whom you loved.

SCROOGE *(softly)*. There was. My sister. Dear little Fan. Sweet little Fan.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Answer the door, Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE. What?

(SFX: Knock at door.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Say, "Come in."

SCROOGE. Come in.

(SFX: Door opens quickly. Rapid little girl footsteps.

MUSIC: Segues to FAN's bright, light and happy music under.)

FAN. Dear, dear big brother!

SCROOGE. Fan!

FAN. Are you surprised to see me?

SCROOGE. I am. Oh … oh … I am. Oh, Fan!

FAN. I have come to bring you home, dear brother! Home for Christmas!

SCROOGE. But how … ?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. She sees you as you were then.

SCROOGE. But not you.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. No.

FAN. We shall go home forever and ever, dear brother! Father is ever so much kinder than he used to be!

SCROOGE. Has he treated you well, little Fan?

FAN. Oh yes! He even spoke to me gently one night as I was going to bed! And he seemed so calm and good that I was not afraid to ask him once more if you might come home to us. And he wasn't angry at all! He said yes, you could come home! Home for good! And he sent me in a coach to bring you!

SCROOGE. Oh, Fan. I wish …

FAN. We're to be together for Christmas, and have the merriest time in all the world!

SCROOGE. God bless you, Fan.

FAN. God bless *you*, big brother! Oh, please do come now! Come with me!

SCROOGE. Yes, Fan … I'll …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. You cannot.

SCROOGE. Ah … go on without me, Fan. I'll be along. Go on now.

FAN. I'll see to having your trunk and boxes tied to the top of the carriage!

(SFX: Running little feet moving away from the mic.)

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FAN *(cont'd)*. Don't be long! Oh, I love you so, Ebbie! And we shall be together again! And it will be the best Christmas ever!

SCROOGE. The best Christmas ever.

FAN. I'll wait at the end of the path!

(SFX: Door closes quickly.

MUSIC: FAN's music fades to silence with her exit.)

SCROOGE. The end of the … end of the path …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Always a delicate creature, whom a breath might have withered. But she had a large heart.

SCROOGE. Yes. Please, Spirit, let me see her again … only a little time longer.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Time is short

SCROOGE. More than we know.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. You never had that Christmas at home, Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE. No. No. The moment I came through the door, Father flew into a rage … chased me from the house. Fan … wept.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. That was long ago.

SCROOGE. Long ago. Yes. Long ago.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. And what became of Fan?

SCROOGE. She grew into a beautiful young woman.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. And died in childbirth.

SCROOGE. Yes.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. The child lived.

SCROOGE. My nephew Fred. He came yesterday to wish me a merry Christmas. I … sent him away.

(MUSIC: Sting, then harp gliss up and under to fade.

SFX: Wind builds and fades.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. The time and place have changed now, Ebenezer Scrooge. Do you know this place?

SCROOGE. I was apprenticed here!

FEZZIWIG *(fading in)*. Boys! Where are you! Dick! Dick Wilkins!

SCROOGE. Why, it's old Fezziwig! Bless him! Old Fezziwig alive again!

FEZZIWIG. Where are you, Wilkins?

DICK. Here, Mr. Fezziwig!

SCROOGE. Dick Wilkins! He was my best friend in those days, Spirit. Poor Dick! Dear Dick!

FEZZIWIG. And where have you left, Ebenezer? That young rascal! Where has he got to?

SCROOGE. Spirit, might I … could I …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Go to him. He will see you as the young man you were.

SCROOGE *(voice grows younger as he speaks)*. Thank you, Spirit. Thank you. Here, sir! I'm here, Mr. Fezziwig!

FEZZIWIG. Ah, there you are, Ebenezer! Sneaking off to spy on the pretty girls, were you?

SCROOGE. Oh, no sir!

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FEZZIWIG *(enormously amused)*. Oh, no sir! Oh, no sir, of course not! You young rogue! No matter, boys, no matter! No more work tonight! It's Christmas Eve! Clear away, my lads! Time for a celebration! We're having a party, boys! Clear away, Dick! Clear away, Ebenezer! Move the furniture back against the walls! Roll up the carpets! Call in the neighbors!

(SFX: Doors are flung open. Multiple footfalls. Furniture scraping.

Background voices off mic. Rhubarb continues under.)

FEZZIWIG *(cont'd)*. Call in the fiddler! Call in the customers and the passersby! We'll dance until the cows come home! We'll celebrate Christmas as it's never been celebrated before!

(MUSIC: FIDDLER plays and fiddle music begins and under.)

MALE PLAYER 4. In came all the young men and women from all over Fezziwig's offices and warehouse.

(Rhubarb and laughter grow and continue under.

SFX: Dancing feet under throughout.)

FEZZIWIG. Everyone's invited! The whole world's invited! Everyone dances! Everyone dances! Find a partner, Dick!

(MUSIC: Keyboard may fade in to accompany fiddle.)

MALE PLAYER 4. In came the housemaid with her cousin the baker. In they all came, some shyly, some boldly, some gracefully, some awkwardly, some pushing, some pulling.

SCROOGE. Dick! Find a partner! *(Laughs.)*

(NOTE: Crowd claps their hands, keeping time to the music.)

DICK *(laughing)*. You find a partner, too, Ebenezer!

MALE PLAYER 4. In they all came anyhow and everyhow, and away they all went! Twenty couples at once, hands half round and back again the other way!

FEZZIWIG. Come, Mrs. Fezziwig! Dance with me!

MALE PLAYER 4. Down the middle and up again; 'round and 'round and starting over!

FEZZIWIG. Yo ho, my boys! Let's have the shutters up, before a man can say Jack Robinson! Hilli-ho!

SCROOGE. Oh, don't let it stop, Spirit! Never let it stop! Leave me here with them forever and ever! I was never as happy as when I was here!

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. A small matter to make these silly people happy.

SCROOGE. Small!

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Don't you think so?

(SFX: Dancing feet [and voices and clapping] fade out through dialog.

MUSIC: Fade out through dialog.)

SCROOGE**.** Fezziwig had the power to make us happy or unhappy, and he chose to make us happy! He chose it! It was a pleasure to work for such a man! So full of joy! He made our work a pleasure! Such an employer! Such a kind … such a … such a benevolent … *(A pause.)*

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GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. And what is it?

SCROOGE. Nothing. I … I was just thinking of my poor clerk, Bob Cratchit. I'm afraid his work isn't what one would call a pleasure.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. But such an employer he has … such a kind … benevolent …

SCROOGE *(quietly).* Stop it. Please stop. I know … I know …

(MUSIC: Sting, then harp gliss up and under to fade.

SFX: Wind and wind chimes.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. My time grows short. Quickly now! The years fly. Behold.

(MUSIC: Melancholy. BELLE's theme under.)

BELLE *(echo)*. Ebenezer …

SCROOGE. Belle! It's … Belle!

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. She loved you once.

SCROOGE. And I loved her.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. You never married.

SCROOGE. N … no.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. She loved another?

SCROOGE. No. But she … It wasn't that I loved her less … I … I loved …

BELLE *(echo)*. You love your money more than you love me, Ebenezer.

SCROOGE. Belle … ?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Stay. She can neither see nor hear you.

SCROOGE. Thank you, Spirit.

BELLE ***(****echo fades out early in speech****).*** A golden idol has replaced me. You fear the world too much, and don't love it enough. I have seen you change from a man of nobility into an evil, twisted slave of greed. Our love was born when we were both poor, but with the acquisition of money, you've changed. You are not the man who loved me. You are not … the man I loved. I release you, Ebenezer.

SCROOGE. Oh … Belle …

BELLE. May you be happy in the life you've chosen. I will not stand between you and your money. *(Voice begins to echo again as she moves away from the mic and fades.)* Goodbye, Ebenezer.

(MUSIC: Fades.

SFX: Wind and wind chime up and under.)

SCROOGE. Spirit! Show me no more! Why do you torture me?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Belle married another.

SCROOGE *(sobbing).* Yes.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. But she kept you in her heart, Ebenezer Scrooge.

SCROOGE *(softly).* And I kept her in mine.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PAST. Her children could have been yours.

SCROOGE. Yes, yes, yes yes yes! Spirit! Remove me from this place! I cannot bear it! Take me back! Take me back! Back to my own room! My own bed! Please! Please! Haunt me no longer! Haunt me no longer!

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(MUSIC: Sting. Dramatic run. Theme in and under.)

ANNOUNCER. After this short break, we will return to the _____ production of Charles Dickens' *A Christmas Carol*!

(MUSIC: Plays out.

"On Air" light goes out.)

P.A. VOICE. And … we're out!

(ACTORS move toward the exits, adlibbing, as the stage lights go down.

Houselights up.)

END OF ACT I

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ACT II

(At the top of the act, the SFX crew is the first in, chatting quietly. Keyboard in next. Actors wander on in small groups and move toward their chairs. Once all are onstage:)

P.A. VOICE: In 10 … nine … eight … seven … six … five … four … three … two … one!

("On Air" light comes on.

MUSIC: Theme to establish and fade under.)

ANNOUNCER. We will return to our drama in a moment, but first a word from our sponsor.

(MUSIC: Button on theme.

Commercials here.

MUSIC: Theme up and under.)

ANNOUNCER *(cont'd)*. And now we return to Philip Grecian's radio adaptation of Charles Dickens' *A Christmas Carol*!

(MUSIC: Theme up and under to fade.

SCROOGE snores.

SFX: The clock strikes one. Bing, bing, bing, ding!)

SCROOGE *(awakens)*. What? The clock? One o'clock! I've slept through the day! Jacob Marley warned me … another spirit, he said … another spirit at one o'clock! *(Whimper.)*

(MUSIC: Up and under.)

MALE PLAYER 2. But no spirit appeared. Five minutes, 10 minutes, nothing. Then, at the quarter hour, though all candles and lamps had long been extinguished in the room, Scrooge became aware of a shaft of light, growing brighter by the moment.

SCROOGE. What's that? The lamp? One of my candles?

MALE PLAYER 2. It wasn't.

SCROOGE. It's coming from the sitting room.

MALE PLAYER 2. It was.

MALE PLAYER 4. Scrooge could see the light shining under and around the closed door.

MALE PLAYER 2. He got up softly, stepped into his slippers, and shuffled to the door.

(SFX: Slippered shuffle.)

MALE PLAYER 2. Then, the moment his hand was on the knob, a voice called out to him.

(MUSIC: Out.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT *(muffled by the closed door)*. Ebenezer Scrooge! Enter, enter, my friend! *(He laughs.)*

MALE PLAYER 2. He threw open the door …

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(SFX: Door knob turns, door opens. Sounds of small bells and jingle bells and tinkly bells and jangly bells of all kinds.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT's laugh is louder now, and less muffled, though it remains under.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(cont'd)*. And the light exploded into his bed chamber. The walls and ceilings of Scrooge's sitting room were covered with holly, mistletoe and ivy, reflecting back the light like so many scattered mirrors …

(SFX: Fireplace.)

MALE PLAYER 1. … and such a mighty blaze went roaring up the chimney as that old hearth had never known in Scrooge's time. Heaped upon the floor to form a kind of throne were turkeys, geese, game, poultry and great joints of meat.

MALE PLAYER 2. Suckling pigs, long wreaths of sausages, mince pies, plum puddings, barrels of oysters, red hot chestnuts, cherry cheeked apples, juicy oranges, luscious pears, immense cakes …

MALE PLAYER 1. … and seething bowls of punch that filled the air with their delicious steaming perfume. Upon this throne sat a jolly giant, wielding a glowing torch shaped like Plenty's horn!

(MUSIC: Fade and end.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT *(laughs)*. Come, Ebenezer Scrooge! Come and know me better, man!

SCROOGE. Must I?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Aye, that you must!

SCROOGE. Who are you, then?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. I am the Ghost of Christmas Present! Look upon me!

MALE PLAYER 1. The giant was clothed in a long green velvet robe, trimmed in white fur. On its head, it wore a holly wreath set here and there with shining icicles. Its eyes sparked and its curly hair and beard were long and free.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. You have never seen the likes of me before!

SCROOGE. Never.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Surely you have met some of my elder brothers and sisters.

SCROOGE. Have you many, Spirit?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. More than eighteen hundred.

SCROOGE. A very large family, indeed.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Aye.

SCROOGE *(sighs, resigned to his fate)*. Spirit, conduct me where you will. Last night … or … I *think* it was last night … I learned a lesson from a spirit. Tonight, if you can, teach me more.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Come, touch my robe.

SCROOGE. Where are we going?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT *(fading back)*. Out into the streets, man!

(MUSIC: Up the scale, then under and end. Harp.

The rest of the cast stays just off mic, creating the sounds of voices in a crowded street.)

SFX: Montage. Horse-drawn carriages. Passing bells. Laughter in groups. Singing carols in groups. Hurdy gurdy, beggars, horse whinny. Street violin. Street accordion. Small dog. Pots and pans clatter and bang as someone walks with them. Street sellers. All continues under.)

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FEMALE PLAYER 1. Scrooge stood unseen with the Spirit, who freely sprinkled incense from his torch over the people as they passed.

(SFX: Torch sprinkle … light run of bells.)

FEMALE PLAYER 1 *(cont'd)*. It was a very uncommon kind of torch, for, whenever there were angry words, it restored good humor immediately.

(SFX: Packages hit paving stones.

MAN and LADY [with packages] ad-lib sounds of running into each other)

MAN. Hey! Steady there! Watch where you're going!
LADY. Me? Look at you! Stumbling along with your packages! Ran right into me!
MAN. No such thing! Now my parcels and packages are scattered all over!
LADY. Mine, as well!
MAN. If you'd been watching it would never have happened!
LADY. You were watching, then?
MAN. I was!
LADY. Then how is it you didn't see me?
MAN. I see you now!
LADY. And what are you going to do about it, then?
MAN. Why, I'm going to …

(SFX: Spirit's torch sprinkle.)

MAN *(cont'd)*. I'm going to … to … help you with your packages.
LADY. Oh. Thank you.

(SFX: Packages picked up and stacked.)

MAN. It doesn't seem I've damaged anything. It was all my fault, you know.
LADY. Nonsense. If I'd watched where I was going this wouldn't have happened. Here. These are yours.
MAN. Thank you. No harm done. Ah, look here! We've collided directly in front of a chocolate shop. Would you care to have something? I'll pay.
LADY. Delighted!
MAN. After all, it's a shame to quarrel upon Christmas Day!
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. And so it is, God love it, so it is.

(SFX: Spirit's torch sprinkle.)

SCROOGE. Spirit, is there a peculiar flavor in what you sprinkle from your torch?
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. There is. My own. The spirit of Christmas.

(SFX: Spirit's torch sprinkle.)

SCROOGE. Why do you sprinkle so much of it over the poorer families as they pass?
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Because they need it most … and treasure it most! Come, I'll show you!

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(SFX: Wind.)

SCROOGE *(moving off mic)*. Where are we going?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT *(moving off mic)*. To the home of your clerk, Bob Cratchit!

(MUSIC: Harp gliss.)

MRS. CRATCHIT. What has ever got your precious father, then? Peter, Belinda, did he say he would be late today?

PETER & BELINDA *(ad-lib)*. No, Mother. He didn't. *(Etc.)*

MRS. CRATCHIT. Bless his heart alive, I've seen nothing like it. He has Tiny Tim with him, too.

PETER. Yes, Mother. Tim especially wanted to go to church today.

MRS. CRATCHIT. I don't understand how they could be so late. Tiny Tim usually sits up on his father's shoulder and keeps him moving right along … and today especially … with Christmas dinner almost ready for the table.

BELINDA. Martha isn't here yet either.

PETER. I'm watching for her!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Martha is later than she's ever been. I do hope nothing has happened to spoil our plans.

PETER. I see her! Here comes Martha!

BELINDA. Martha's here, Mother!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Get the door, Peter.

PETER. Yes, Mother!

(SFX: Door opens.)

MARTHA. Merry Christmas, Mother!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Merry Christmas, Martha! How late you are!

(SFX: Door closes.)

MARTHA. I'm sorry, Mother. We'd a deal of work to finish up last night and had to clear away this morning.

MRS. CRATCHIT. Well then, as long as you've come. Sit you down by the fire and have a warm.

PETER. There's Father coming!

BELINDA. With Tiny Tim!

PETER. Hide, Martha, hide!

PETER, BELINDA & MRS. CRATCHIT *(Ad-lib)* "Over here." "No, hide behind the door." "The bedroom, hide in the bedroom!" etc.

(SFX: Some scurrying about, furniture scraping. Door opens.)

CRATCHIT. Merry Christmas, one and all! Wish everyone a merry Christmas, Tim!

TIM. Merry Christmas!

CRATCHIT. That's the boy! Merry Christmas! Merry Christmas!

TIM. Merry Christmas, Belinda! Merry Christmas, Peter!

CRATCHIT. Why … where's our Martha? She was coming today, wasn't she?

MRS. CRATCHIT. No, I'm afraid she's not coming this Christmas.

CRATCHIT. Not coming! Not coming upon Christmas day! Oh … but …

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MARTHA. Surprise!

(PETER and BELINDA laugh and ad-lib: "Martha's here!" "She was hiding!" "Are you surprised, Father?" "Look, Tim, Martha's here!" Etc.)

CRATCHIT. Martha! Hiding from me! You did come!

MARTHA. Of course I came, Father! How could I not on Christmas!

(PETER and BELINDA laugh at the great trick they have pulled on their father.)

PETER. Let Tim down, Father!

BELINDA. We want to show him

PETER. Come into the kitchen, Tim!

BELINDA. Oh, do, Tim! Mother has made the most wonderful pudding!

PETER. It's not out yet, but you can hear it singing in the copper!

BELINDA. It smells so like Christmas should smell!

PETER. Come see!

TIM. Oh! I have to see! Let me down, please, Father!

CRATCHIT. Down you go, then, Tim! Not so fast! Here, take your crutch first!

PETER. Come, Tim! *(Fading.)* Come see!

TIM. I'm coming! *(Fading.)* I'm coming!

(PETER and BELINDA ad-lib: "Come, Tim, hurry!" Etc. Fading.

SFX: Footfalls of the other two, and Tim's crutch on the floor, fading.)

CRATCHIT. Ah! What would Christmas be without a visit from the eldest daughter, eh, Martha? Why, it's all Tim has talked of all week!

MRS. CRATCHIT. How did Tim behave today?

CRATCHIT. As good as gold … and better. Somehow, you know, he gets thoughtful sitting there by himself. He told me, coming home, that he hoped the people in church saw him looking so happy … and … and bright … because they might forget their own troubles, and remember who made the lame walk, and enter into the spirit and meaning of Christmas all the more. *(Feebly.)* He's … he's growing stronger, you know, stronger every day.

MARTHA. Yes, of course he is, Father.

(PETER, BELINDA and TIM re-enter, ad-libbing off mic.

SFX: Rapid children's footsteps and a wooden crutch fade in.)

TIM. You should smell the pudding, Father!

PETER. A perfect pudding!

TIM. The best pudding ever in the world!

CRATCHIT. Oho! And what makes you such an expert on puddings?

TIM. Haven't I tasted the puddings Mother makes every year?

CRATCHIT. Indeed you have.

TIM. They're the best puddings that could ever be … and this pudding is the best of the best!

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CRATCHIT *(laughing)*. The best of the best! I'll wager it is, Tim, I'll wager it is!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Come, children, time for dinner.

CRATCHIT. You hear that, Tim! Quick, Peter, run and fetch the goose from the oven!

PETER. Yes, Father!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Martha, Belinda, finish the table!

MARTHA & BELINDA *(ad-lib)*. Yes, Mother! Right away, Mother!

(SFX: Feet scurry. Table settings.)

CRATCHIT. Tim, you shall sit at the head of the table with me! Hurry now!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Here's Peter with the roast goose!

PETER. The goose!

CRATCHIT. The goose! Just look at it!

TIM. See the goose, Martha!

CRATCHIT. Never was there such a Christmas goose! Merry Christmas, everyone, Merry Christmas!

TIM. Hurrah! Merry Christmas!

(All ad-lib: "Merry Christmas!" "Such a goose!" Etc., moving away from the mic and fading.

MUSIC: Transit out of scene.)

SCROOGE. Cratchit has a very large family. I … I had no idea.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Have you ever asked?

SCROOGE *(ashamed)*. No. It seems such a small meal for such a large family.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. But honestly come by. Your clerk works very hard for his 15 shillings a week.

SCROOGE. I see no presents for the children.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. There isn't money enough. They keep Christmas in their hearts, not their pocketbooks. They give presents of love.

SCROOGE. What of Tiny Tim? Such a frail little fellow. Will he …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Ssssh … time passes. They've done with their meal.

(MUSIC: Transit into scene.)

CRATCHIT. The pudding, my dears! Time for the pudding!

TIM. The pudding! It's time for the pudding.

MRS. CRATCHIT *(fading in)*. Here comes the pudding! Here comes the pudding!

CRATCHIT. Smell that? Smell the pudding?

MARTHA. A beautiful pudding!

PETER. A perfect pudding!

BELINDA. A wonderful pudding!

CRATCHIT. An excellent pudding!

SCROOGE. A wretchedly small pudding.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Bigger in their eyes than in yours; and the finest tasting pudding in all of London, I'll vow.

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CRATCHIT. A merry Christmas to us all, my dears!

ALL. Merry Christmas! *(Ad-lib.)*

CRATCHIT. A toast!

ALL. A toast! *(Ad-lib.)*

CRATCHIT. To Mr. Scrooge! The founder of the feast!

MRS. CRATCHIT. The founder of the feast indeed! I wish I had your Mr. Scrooge here right now, Bob Cratchit. I'd give him a piece of my mind to feast upon!

CRATCHIT. My dear. The children. Christmas day.

MRS. CRATCHIT. To drink to the health of such a stingy, hard, unfeeling man as Mr. Scrooge! We carry the Christmas spirit too far!

TIM. No, Mother. Mr. Scrooge needs Christmas as much as we do. Even more.

MRS. CRATCHIT. Oooh, Tim. *(Sigh.)* Very well, then. I'll drink to his health … but only because it's Christmas day.

CRATCHIT. That's the way! To Mr. Scrooge!

ALL . To Mr. Scrooge!

CRATCHIT. God bless him!

ALL. God bless him!

CRATCHIT. And God bless us!

TIM. God bless us every one!

(They all laugh.)

CRATCHIT. Special announcement! Young Master Timothy Cratchit will grace us with a song from his vast repertoire!

MARTHA. Oh yes, a song, Tim! Sing us a song!

ALL. Yes. Do! *(Ad-lib.)*

(TIM sings a Christmas carol—"What Child Is This," in a sweet, clear voice, a cappella. Establish, then under dialog, as the actor steps back from the mic.)

SCROOGE. They all seem so … happy.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Aye.

SCROOGE. But … but they're poor. I don't pay Cratchit enough for one man to …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Oho! Now it's out, eh? You don't pay Bob Cratchit enough for one man to live decently, yet he supports a family.

SCROOGE. I was going to say …

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Yes, I know what you were going to say. The strength of that family lies in the family itself, not in the paltry sum Bob Cratchit brings home. Love is the main element there, not money.

SCROOGE. Spirit, tell me if Tiny Tim will live.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. If these shadows remain unaltered by the future, I see a vacant seat in the chimney corner, and a small crutch without an owner.

(TIM's voice under is suddenly cut off mid-word.)

SCROOGE. No, no! Oh no, kind Spirit! Say he will be spared! There are hospitals …

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GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. "If he is going to die, he had better do it and decrease the surplus population!" Whose words are those?

SCROOGE. My … my own.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Why, man, what right have you? How hateful you are! You are less fit to live than millions like this poor child!

SCROOGE. But, Spirit … I didn't know. I …

(FRED laughs heartily … slightly off mic.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Who's that?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Your nephew.

SCROOGE. My nephew? Fred? What's he doing at Cratchit's house?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. He's not. And neither are we.

(MUSIC: Harp.)

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT *(cont'd)*. Welcome to the home of your nephew!

FRED *(laughing, on mic).* And he said Christmas was a humbug!

(The cast, as guests at FRED's party, ad-lib reactions.)

TOPPER. A humbug!

FRED. A humbug! And he believed it, too!

(The cast laughs.)

FRED'S WIFE. He's an evil old thing.

FRED. Why bless you, wife of mine, you've put on *such* a serious face!

(Mild laughter from the cast.)

FRED *(cont'd)*. Uncle Scrooge is a comical old fellow, to be sure, and not as pleasant as he might be; but he suffers for it. I don't … I can't condemn him. He condemns himself.

TOPPER. Well put.

FRED. Thank you, Topper.

FRED'S WIFE. He's very rich, Fred.

FRED. Who? Topper? Then why hasn't he ever invited us to *his* house for Christmas dinner?

(Laughter from the cast.)

FRED'S WIFE. No, I mean your Uncle Scrooge!

FRED. My uncle's wealth doesn't do him a bit of good. He lives like a rat.

TOPPER. A rat in a hole. I've seen his rooms.

FRED. As have I, and I'm sorry for him. He won't come to Christmas dinner with us; he stays home and eats his gruel. He only punishes himself.

PARTYGOER 1. And he's missed an excellent dinner!

PARTYGOER 2. That he has!

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(Agreement and laughter from the cast.)

FRED'S WIFE. Let's talk of something else. He's an evil old thing, and I won't have my Christmas ruined with talk of him.

FRED. Absolutely right, my dear. What shall we talk about instead?

TOPPER. Let's play "Yes and No!"

FRED. A splendid idea! "Yes and No" it is! Who will begin?

TOPPER. You start, Fred!

(Ad-libbing from the other guests: "Yes, Fred, you begin," etc.)

FRED. Very well. I'll be something, and you must guess what I am. Ready?

FRED'S WIFE. Ready.

(Agreement from the other guests, who will also share ideas off mic, under main dialogue.)

FRED. So am I. Begin. Guess what I am.

FRED'S WIFE. Are you a vegetable?

FRED. No.

PARTYGOER 3. A mineral?

FRED. No.

TOPPER. Then you're an animal!

FRED. Yes.

TOPPER. He's an animal!

FRED'S WIFE. A jungle animal?

FRED. No.

PARTYGOER 4. A fish?

FRED. No.

TOPPER *(to no one in particular)*. Is an insect an animal?

FRED. Yes.

TOPPER. Aha! All right, then! Are you an insect?

FRED. No.

PARTYGOER 5. A country animal?

FRED. No.

PARTYGOER 4. A city animal?

FRED. Yes.

PARTYGOER 6. A dog?

FRED. No.

SCROOGE. A city animal … a city animal … Oh, Spirit, I know they can't hear me, but … Ah! Are you a man?

FRED'S WIFE. Do you have four legs?

FRED. No.

TOPPER. Are you an insect with many legs?

FRED. I told you, Topper, I'm not an insect!

TOPPER. Oh! Oh! Right! I had forgotten!

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SCROOGE. Ask him if he's a man! Somebody ask him if he's a man.
PARTYGOER 5. Are you a disagreeable animal?
FRED. Yes.
PARTYGOER 3. Do you grunt and growl?
FRED. Yes.
SCROOGE. He's a banker!
FRED'S WIFE. Are you a vicious animal?
FRED. Oh yes.
CAST. Aaaaaah! *(General ad-libbing, trying to put the clues together.)*
TOPPER. Do you have sharp teeth?
FRED. Uh … no.
SCROOGE. A man! You're a man! He's a man! Oh, Spirit, this is wonderful fun! Wonderful! I never knew there could be such …
PARTYGOER 4. Do you live in London?
FRED. Yes.

(Excitement from the cast. They've narrowed it down. They compare notes.)

SCROOGE *(over it all)*. You hear that? London … London … He lives in London!
FRED'S WIFE. A horse?
FRED. No.
PARTYGOER 1. A canary?
FRED. No.
PARTYGOER 5. A toad?
FRED. No.
SCROOGE *(in a frenzy)*. A man! He's a man! Somebody guess!
FRED'S WIFE. An animal we might see in the street?
FRED. Yes.
TOPPER. Ah! Ah! A tiger!
FRED *(patiently)*. Topper, there aren't any tigers in the streets of London.
TOPPER. Oh. How about a bear, then?
FRED *(with exasperation)*. No.
PARTYGOER 3. A cat.
FRED. No.
PARTYGOER 2. A mouse.
FRED. No.
TOPPER. Oh! Oh! Wait! Wait! I know! I've found it out! I know what Fred is!
SCROOGE. He knows! He knows, Spirit! Topper knows, everyone! Tell! Tell!
CAST *(ad-lib)*. What? What is he? *(Etc.)*
TOPPER. A man!
FRED. Yes!

(Excitement now from the cast.)

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FRED *(cont'd)*. But which man?
TOPPER. Queen Victoria!
FRED. Is Queen Victoria a man?
TOPPER. None of *my* business.
FRED. No. Not Queen Victoria.
TOPPER. Prince Albert, then.
FRED. No.
PARTYGOER 5. Wait, wait, what do we know? He's a disagreeable animal …

(Cast ad-libs, filling in the clues.)

PARTYGOER 1. He grunts and growls.
PARTYGOER 2. A vicious animal.
TOPPER. Maybe a tiger.
FRED. Not a tiger!
TOPPER. Right. Not a tiger. I've got it!
SCROOGE. Spirit, you hear that? He knows the man! Topper knows the man!
CAST *(ad-lib)*. Who? Who is it? What's the name?
TOPPER. Uncle Scrooge!
FRED. Yes!

(Much laughter and ad-libbing among the cast and under.)

SCROOGE *(laughing)*. You hear that, Spirit! It is I! I'm the disagreeable animal!
FRED *(as the laughter dies)*. Ah well, my uncle has given us plenty of merriment, and it would be ungrateful not to drink his health. To my Uncle Scrooge!
CAST. Uncle Scrooge!
FRED. A merry Christmas and a happy New Year to the old man!
CAST *(ad-lib)*. A merry Christmas! *(Etc.)*
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Come. We must go.
SCROOGE. Oh! Must we? It's all been so … happy!
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. We must … come.

(MUSIC: Establish and under.)

MALE PLAYER 2. They went far and saw much … visiting many homes where the spirit's torch brought the happiness of the Christmas spirit. They stood beside sick beds, and those who suffered were cheerful. They brought the comforts of holiday and home to those who were away in foreign lands.
MALE PLAYER 5. They stood with those in despair, and brought hope … with those in poverty who were, for the time, rich in spirit. It was a long night, though Scrooge felt that it was more than a single night … and observed that the spirit grew visibly older until, finally, its hair was thin and white.

(MUSIC: End.)

SCROOGE. Are spirits lives so short?
GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. My life upon this earth ends tonight.

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SCROOGE. Tonight?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Aye. Tonight at midnight.

SCROOGE. Forgive me for asking, Spirit, but in all the time we've been together … I've noticed … from time to time … something at your feet … hiding under your robe.

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Aye.

SCROOGE. May I ask … ?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. You may! And since you ask, look here, man! Behold!

(SFX: The sudden murmur of heavy cloth.

MUSIC: Terrible revelation.

SCROOGE gasps.)

MALE PLAYER 2. Two demon children crouched at the spirit's feet … wretched, frightful and hideous. They clung to its legs. Scrooge stepped back and covered his eyes.

SCROOGE. Horrible!

(MUSIC: Heavy and menacing.)

MALE PLAYER 2. A boy and girl. Meager, ragged, scowling and wolfish … their features stale and shriveled, pinched and twisted. Where angels lived in other children, devils lurked in these … glaring out and menacing. Nothing could prepare Scrooge for the sight of these shriveled monsters.

SCROOGE. Spirit! Are they yours?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. They are man's.

SCROOGE. Man's?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. The boy is Ignorance. The girl is Want. Beware of them both, but most of all, beware of this boy.

SCROOGE. Have they no refuge or resource? Is there no hope for them? And Tiny Tim! Is there no hope for Tiny Tim?

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Are there no prisons?

SCROOGE. Don't mock me!

GHOST OF CHRISTMAS PRESENT. Are there no workhouses? Are there no prisons? *(Backing away from the mic.)* Are there no workhouses?

(The cast, off mic, takes up the lines, repeating, overlapping, accelerating. Fade in echo. After the first line of narration, the cast voices fade out.

MUSIC: Underscore. Fade out during last sentence of narration below.

SFX: Clock chime the hour of midnight, simultaneously with voices.)

MALE PLAYER 2 *(begins during last chimes)*. Scrooge had fallen to his knees and buried his head. Then, at the final stroke of midnight, he lifted up his eyes to find the Spirit, and beheld, instead, a solemn towering phantom, draped and hooded in a deep black garment concealing its face and form. It glided toward him, like a mist along the ground.

SCROOGE. Are you the Ghost of Christmas Yet to Come?

(MUSIC: A low echoing two-note theme will stand for the sound of the Ghost of Christmas Yet to Come.)

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SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. And you have come to show me the shadows of things that have not happened, but will happen? My future? Is that so, Spirit?

(MUSIC: Echoing notes.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Oh, Spirit, I fear you more than any of the others I've seen. But … but I know you mean only to do me good. I'm ready. Show me the future.

(SFX: Wind.

MUSIC: Harp gliss.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Where are we, spirit? Oh. Why … why we've returned to Bob Cratchit's house. Are we now going to see things that haven't happened? Things that will happen … in the future?

(MUSIC: Echoing notes.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. But why here? Why have we come here again? Why have we … Spirit … where is Tiny Tim?

(MUSIC: Very short three-note transition.)

MRS. CRATCHIT. Peter?

PETER. Yes, Mother?

MRS. CRATCHIT. Isn't it time for your father to be home?

PETER. Past time.

MRS. CRATCHIT. Go to the window and watch for him, will you, Peter?

PETER. He walks a little slower than he used to … these last few evenings, Mother.

MRS. CRATCHIT *(trying to be cheerful)*. Slower, why … why … I have known him to walk very fast indeed with … *(She realizes what she is saying.)* with Tiny Tim on his … shoulder. Very … fast, indeed.

BELINDA. So have I, Mother.

PETER. Yes, often.

MRS. CRATCHIT. But Tiny Tim was very light to carry, you know … and his father loved him so that … that it was no trouble.

BELINDA. No trouble at all …

MRS. CRATCHIT. No trouble … at all …

PETER. There's father coming!

(SFX: Door opens.)

CRATCHIT. Good evening, my dear … Belinda … Peter …

MRS. CRATCHIT. Oh! Sit down, Bob, sit down, there's tea on the hob. Peter, get your father some tea!

PETER. Yes, Mother!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Bob … did you … did you go today to see …

CRATCHIT. Yes I did.

(SFX: Door closes.)

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CRATCHIT *(cont'd)*. I wish you could have been with me. It would have done you good to see how beautiful it is. It's on a hill … and it looks out on this … this gentle slope of snow. You know how snow is … when it's new. Pure and white … with these little sparkling points of light scattered, you know … like little … little Christmas diamonds for my … my Tiny Tim. Oh, but you'll see it often. I knelt there and promised him that we would come again on Sunday. All of us.

(MRS. CRATCHIT sobs.)

CRATCHIT *(cont'd)*. There, there now, my dear. Why, what would Tim say if he saw you like this? "Why, Mother," he'd say, "Christmas is a time for making merry … for counting our blessings … " *(A moment.)* Our … blessings. *(New thought.)* I … I saw Mr. Scrooge's nephew today.

BELINDA. Mr. Fred?

CRATCHIT. Yes, Mr. Fred. He saw that I looked a little … just a little down, you know, and he asked what was troubling my mind. Well … I told him. And he said, "I am heartily sorry, Mr. Cratchit." He remembered my name, you see. "I am heartily sorry," he said, "and sorry for your good wife, too." Though how he knew that I'll never know.

MRS. CRATCHIT. Knew what?

CRATCHIT. That you were a good wife.

(She laughs through her tears.)

CRATCHIT *(cont'd, gently)*, Ah, that's more like it now.

PETER. What else did he say, Father?

CRATCHIT. Well, Peter, he … he said that if he could be of any service, I should come to him. And he gave me his card. He was so kind … it really seemed as if he had known our Tiny Tim.

BELINDA. I wish he had.

CRATCHIT. Yes, I think he would have loved Tim as we did. Such a … such a patient and mild little fellow, Tim was. We were very lucky to have had him with us … even for such a short time. *(A pause.)* Now everyone run for your coats. We'll go out and listen to the carolers. There's a fine snow coming down now.

BELINDA. It's snowing?

PETER. Truly?

CRATCHIT. Hurry! Run for your coats! Hurry!

MRS. CRATCHIT. Come, children!

(SFX: Scurrying feet.

PETER, BELINDA and MRS. CRATCHIT ad-lib their exit and fade.

MUSIC: Under CRATCHIT. Melancholy.)

CRATCHIT. Tim? I … I don't know if you can hear me, son … but … we're going to be … we're going to be just fine, Tim. Just … fine. Oh, and … and, Tim … Merry Christmas, son. Merry Christmas.

(MUSIC: Change pace under SCROOGE. Fade after "not too late!")

SCROOGE. Spirit! This cannot be! You mustn't let this happen! Not Tiny Tim! Tell me that it's not too late!

(MUSIC: Echoing notes of Spirit's "voice." Harp gliss.)

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SCROOGE. Where are we? This isn't the Cratchit house. Wait, I recognize it! We're in the street … near my house. Why are we here?

(On the street, BUSINESSMAN 1, 2 and 3 laugh and fade in.)

BUSINESSMAN 1. No, I don't know much about it either way. I only know he's dead.

BUSINESSMAN 2. When did he die?

BUSINESSMAN 3. Last night, I believe.

SCROOGE. Who are they talking about, Spirit? Is it Tiny Tim?

BUSINESSMAN 2. I thought he'd never die. What was the matter with him?

BUSINESSMAN 1. I don't really care. He's dead. That's all that matters. In fact, I don't think anyone will care much.

SCROOGE. My my. Whoever it is wasn't very well liked. Must've been a *terrible* sort of person.

BUSINESSMAN 3. What has he done with his money?

BUSINESSMAN 1. Well, he hasn't left it to me, I know that much!

(The three men laugh.)

BUSINESSMAN 2. It won't be a very large funeral.

BUSINESSMAN 1. It will be a very *cheap* funeral.

BUSINESSMAN 3. Why, man, who would go? I can't think of anyone who would.

BUSINESSMAN 2. I don't mind going if a lunch is provided free. But they must feed me, and I'll only stay as long as there is food to be had!

(They laugh as they fade back and out.)

SCROOGE. Spirit, what villain has died? Who could be so terrible that these men would feel no compassion at his passing?

PASSERBY 1. Hello! How are you?

PASSERBY 2. Very good. And you?

PASSERBY 1. Well, thank you. I see the old man's finally gone to keep the devil company.

PASSERBY 2. So I'm told. Cold, isn't it?

PASSERBY 1. Yes. Christmas, you know.

PASSERBY 2. Quite.

PASSERBY 1. Good morning, then.

PASSERBY 2. Good morning.

SCROOGE. Who are they talking about? Who?

(MUSIC: Transition. Establish and under.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Where are we going, Spirit? Where are we … I don't know this street. Wait. There's a sign … "Field Lane." Oh! We're in Saffron Hill!

(MUSIC: Continue under.)

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FEMALE PLAYER 2. Saffron Hill, a collection of filthy shops. A colony of petty larceny, inhabited by those who traffic in stolen and salvaged goods. Here could be found wads of silk handkerchiefs resold by the pickpockets who spirited them away, old iron and bones and heaps of mildewed wool and linen, rust and rot.

FEMALE PLAYER 4. Alleys and archways, like so many cesspools, disgorged their offenses of smell and dirt and life upon the straggling streets, and the whole quarter reeked with crime, filth and misery. Here sat a low-browed beetling shop where iron, bones, bottles and charnel house viscera were bought.

MALE PLAYER 4. Inside were secrets that few would scrutinize, hidden in mountains of unseemly rags, masses of corrupted fat. And in the middle of it all, by a charcoal stove, sat a great, greasy spider of a man smoking his pipe.

(MUSIC: Out.

SFX: Door squeals open.)

MRS. DILBER. Old Joe! You in?

OLD JOE. Well, well, well, Mrs. Dilber! And you've not come alone!

MRS. DILBER. We run into each other down the way. We all been to the same treasure trove and come with plunder. This here's the Widow Krook …

OLD JOE. Widow Krook.

WIDOW KROOK. Let's get on with it, then.

MRS. DILBER. These things is done with ceremony. Introductions first. And, final, o' course, you know the undertaker's man, Mr. Whitlow.

OLD JOE. Whitlow.

WHITLOW. Pleasure.

OLD JOE. Look at the three of ye bearin' gifts for Old Joe like as if you was the magi theirselves! When would you three meet again, eh? You couldn'ta done it in a better place! Come in, come in. All the way. Shut the door after.

(SFX: Door squeals close.)

WIDOW KROOK. Listen to it skreek!

OLD JOE. Ain't a bit of rusty metal in this place as its own hinges, and no such old bones here as mine! Whaddya got? Undertaker's man first.

(SFX: We hear each item hit the countertop.)

WHITLOW. I got two keys, a pencil case, a pair of sleeve buttons and a brooch … of no great value.

OLD JOE. No great value at all.

WHITLOW. It's not fair! By the time I get to 'em, they've been picked over good.

OLD JOE. Still, business is business. So there …

(SFX: A few coins dropped in the man's hand.)

OLD JOE *(cont'd)*. That's your account, and I wouldn't give another sixpence if I was to be boiled for not doin' it. Who's next? Mrs. Dilber, Widow Krook?

WIDOW KROOK. I'll wait.

OLD JOE. Best for last, eh, Widow.

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MRS. DILBER. Here's mine, Joe.

OLD JOE. Let's see what ye have, then, Mrs. Dilber …

(SFX: Whooshing of cloth, clunk of boots on counter, silver clatter.)

OLD JOE. … Sheets and towels … a pair of boots, two old fashioned silver teaspoons, a pair of sugar tongs and a coat … somewhat the worse for wear. Ah, I always give too much to the ladies. It's a weakness, and that's the way I ruin m'self. Here's your account, then …

(SFX: More and heavier coins.)

OLD JOE *(cont'd)*. If ye asks me for another penny, I'd repent of bein' so liberal, and take back half a crown.

WIDOW KROOK. Now undo *my* bundle, Joe!

OLD JOE *(we hear the action in his voice)*. All right, then …

(SFX: Heavy fabric moving.)

OLD JOE *(cont'd)*. What's this, then? Bed curtains!

WIDOW KROOK. Bed curtains! *(Triumphant.)* His own!

(SFX: Curtain rings against one another.)

OLD JOE. His own curtain rings, too! You don't mean to say you took 'em down, rings and all, with him lyin' there?

WIDOW KROOK. Yes I do. Why not!

OLD JOE. You were born to make your fortune. What's this? His blankets?

WIDOW KROOK. Whose else's ya think? He isn't likely to take cold without 'em.

OLD JOE. And this …

WIDOW KROOK. You may look through that shirt till your eyes ache, but y'won't find a hole in it. It's the best he had. They'd've wasted it, hadn't been for me.

OLD JOE. Wasted it?

WIDOW KROOK. They had it on 'im to be buried in. But I took it.

OLD JOE. You … took it off 'im … while he was …

WIDOW KROOK. If calico ain't good enough for such a purpose, it ain't good enough for nothin'. He can't look any uglier.

MRS. DILBER. Mercy.

WHITLOW. I should've had that shirt, by rights!

OLD JOE. Pipe down, Whitlow. You get plenty. Got anything else, Widow?

WIDOW KROOK. That's the lot.

OLD JOE. Good. I feared y'might be marketing the corpse itself.

WIDOW KROOK. Nooooo.

OLD JOE. All right, then.

WIDOW KROOK. People on the street. I couldn'ta got it out.

MRS. DILBER. Why wasn't he a natural sort of bloke in his lifetime, that's what I'd just like t'know.

WHITLOW. That's the Lord's own truth, ain't it?

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WIDOW KROOK. He wouldn't give a poor old woman tuppence, don't I know. If he'd just been nicer to people, he might've had somebody lookin' after 'im when he was sick … 'stead o' dyin' all alone by 'isself in 'is room.

MRS. DILBER. Truer words was never spoke. It's a judgment on that's what it is. *(Backing away from the mic, fading.)* I don't think 'e was ever kind to nobody in 'is life.

SCROOGE. Spirit, please, I know there must be some lesson to be learned in the death of this man they speak of. No one could love such a man. Tell me his name.

(MUSIC: Transition. Establish and under.

SFX: Horse drawn cabs pass.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. We're back on the street! Where are we off to now, Spirit? Are we …

PASSING BROTHER. Merry Christmas, brother.

SCROOGE. He sees me?

(MUSIC: Echoing notes of Spirit's voice.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Um … Merry Christmas. Tell me … brother … have you heard about the man who died last night?

PASSING BROTHER. Oh my yes! The whole district's buzzing with the news! Mind you, I didn't know him myself, but from the talk I've heard, we're better off without him. He was a nasty old miser. No one mourns him.

SCROOGE *(eagerly)*. His name. Do you know his name?

PASSING BROTHER. Why of course. Doesn't everyone? It's Ebenezer Scrooge. Ebenezer Scrooge died last night. *(Fading.)* Merry Christmas, brother!

SCROOGE. Spirit! I'm the one who died! I'm the one nobody mourned! Spirit! Hear me! I am not the man I was! Assure me that I may yet change these shadows you have shown me! That I may make Tiny Tim well again … that he won't die! That I may alter my life … and become a good man!

(SFX: Wind comes up, stronger and louder. Fades during the next speech.

MUSIC: Eerie chords. Harp gliss up then under, fades.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. I will honor Christmas in my heart and keep the spirit of Christmas all year round! I will live in the past, the present and the future!

All three spirits will live in me! I have learned my lesson! Spirit! Spirit! Spirit! Wh … what … why … why … I'm back in my own bed! But how could … ? Another chance! I'm being given another chance! I'm not dead! And Tiny Tim's not dead! Another chance for Tiny Tim!

I'll be good, Spirits! I'll be good from now on! Another chance! Tiny Tim won't die! I'll … I'll send him to doctors … the best doctors! I don't know what to do! I'm as light as a feather!

As happy as an angel! Merry Christmas! Merry Christmas to all the world! Oh my … *(He laughs.)*

Oh my, I don't know what day it is! I don't know how many days I traveled with the spirits. Under the influence of spirits! *(Laughs.)*

(SFX: SCROOGE's light footsteps.)

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SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Oh, I like that! Under the influence of spirits! I don't know … *(Tickled.)* I don't know anything! I'm a baby! *(Laughs.)* A little baby! But … I … don't … care! I like being a baby! *(Chants.)* I like being a baby! I like being a baby! Oh, look out the window! A boy down on the street, do you see that? Do you see that? Who am I talking to? There's no one here but me. I hope! *(Laugh.)*

(SFX: Window opens.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd, calling out)*. Boy! Oh, boy! You there!

BOY *(off mic)*. Who, me?

SCROOGE. Yes! Yes, you! What's today, my fine fellow?

BOY. Today? Why, it's Christmas day!

SCROOGE. It's Christmas day! I haven't missed it! The spirits have done it all in one night … or they sent me back, or … They can do anything they like! Anything! You know that, don't you? Of course you do! Of course you do! Who am I talking to? Only me! *(Calling out.)* Hello, my fine fellow!

BOY. Hello!

SCROOGE. Do you know the poulterer's shop at the corner?

BOY. Yes, sir.

SCROOGE. Oh, an intelligent boy! A remarkable boy! Have they sold that prize turkey that was hanging up there? The big one?

BOY. What, the one as big as me?

SCROOGE. Oh, a delightful boy! A pleasure to talk to him. Yes, my lad, the one as big as you.

BOY. It's still there, sir!

SCROOGE. Good! Go and tell them to bring it here to me, and I'll buy it! And I'll tell them where to take it! Come back with the man, and I'll give you a shilling!

BOY. A shilling!

SCROOGE. Come back in less than five minutes, and I'll give you half a crown!

BOY. Half a crown! Yes, sir! *(His voice fades.)* I'll be back, sir! Half a crown!

(SFX: Closes window.)

SCROOGE. I'll send it to Bob Cratchit. He won't know who sent it! *(Laughing.)* Why, it's twice as big as Tiny Tim! Oh, I must dress … and meet the turkey downstairs … *(Laughing.)* No! Not the turkey, the … quickly! I'll have Christmas dinner with my nephew Fred! *(Laughing.)* Won't he be surprised, though! *(He moves away from the mic, laughing.)*

(MUSIC: Happy music, establish and under.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3. Oh, what a time old Scrooge had that Christmas. He had dinner with Fred, and sang carols … and played games … including "Yes and No," which he won every time! And after dinner he went 'round to all the shops and pounded on the doors until they were opened to him.

FEMALE PLAYER 1. And he brought presents for all the Cratchits and had them sent to their house. But he instructed the shopkeepers not to tell who sent the presents. And by the time night fell, he had spent more money on presents and food for the poor and needy than he had ever spent on anything in his entire life.

FEMALE PLAYER 3. And he was happier than he'd ever been in his life. But he was early at the office the next morning, so he could catch Bob Cratchit coming in late. And Bob *was* late.

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(SFX: Clock begins to strike and under.)

FEMALE PLAYER 1. Bob and his family had stayed up the night before celebrating the strangest and most wonderful Christmas they'd ever had, for a good Christmas spirit, by the name of Ebenezer Scrooge, had sent food and gifts and clothes to the Cratchit household.

FEMALE PLAYER 3. The clock finished striking nine …

(SFX: Clock finishes striking.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3 *(cont'd)*. No Bob. Fifteen minutes past nine …

(SFX: Clock strikes the quarter hour.)

FEMALE PLAYER 3 *(cont'd)*. No Bob. And then, at nine-thirty …

(MUSIC: Fades and ends under.

SFX: Clock strikes once. Door opens quickly. Sound of slight wind. Door closes carefully. Wind stops.)

SCROOGE. Cratchit!

CRATCHIT *(withering)*. Yes, sir?

SCROOGE. What do you mean by coming in here at this time of day?

CRATCHIT. I'm very sorry, sir, I'm behind my time.

SCROOGE. Yes, you are. Behind your time a whole 30 minutes! Come here, Cratchit!

CRATCHIT. It's only once a year, sir. It won't happen again. I'm afraid I was making rather merry yesterday, Mr. Scrooge. You see, someone delivered … I mean … we were surprised to … It was …

SCROOGE. Cratchit, I'm not going to stand for this sort of behavior any longer!

CRATCHIT. No, sir.

SCROOGE. And I see no choice but to … raise your salary!

CRATCHIT. Please, sir, I can't … What?

SCROOGE. That's right. *(Chuckling.)* You heard me. Raise your salary.

CRATCHIT. Raise my …

SCROOGE. Merry Christmas, Bob. A merry, merry Christmas! Can you ever forgive an old fool?

CRATCHIT *(stunned)*. Yes, sir. I mean … no, sir … you're not a fool, sir … I …

SCROOGE. I'm going to raise your salary … and I want to help you to raise that family of yours, too! We're going to get Tiny Tim the best doctors in the world! He's going to be fine, Bob! He'll grow up strong and healthy! And we'll see if we can't find your oldest boy, Peter, a good position where he can learn a trade. Belinda, too! And schooling! The children will all need the best schooling! It's too cold in here. Put some more coals on the fire!

CRATCHIT. Yes, sir.

SCROOGE. No, no … never mind, I'll do it! Here, you sit at my desk!

(SFX: Scuffing of chair, hard sit down.)

SCROOGE *(cont'd)*. Make yourself at home! Sit in my chair! Put your feet up! I'll bring you a nice Christmas bowl of smoking bishop! It's about time, isn't it, Bob? A merry, merry Christmas to you, Bob Cratchit! A merry Christmas to everybody!

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(MUSIC: Up and under.)

STORYTELLER *(SCROOGE actor drops character)*. Scrooge was better than his word. He did it all and more. And to Tiny Tim, who did *not* die, he was a second father. He became as good a friend, as good a master, and as good a man as the good old city knew. Some laughed at him, but he let them laugh, for he was wise enough to know that nothing ever happens that some people don't laugh. It was enough for him that he was happy. He never saw the spirits again, but he learned their lessons well, for it was always said of him that he knew how to keep Christmas better than any other man. May that truly be said of all of us. And so, as Tiny Tim observed:

(MUSIC: Single note, sustained.)

TIM. God blesss us, every one!

(MUSIC: Up and under credits and out.)

ANNOUNCER. You have been listening to the radio dramatization, *A Christmas Carol*, written by Philip Grecian, based on the novel by Charles Dickens, and presented by _____! And so … Good night, happy holidays and Merry Christmas!

CAST. Merry Christmas!

(MUSIC: Theme to end.)

THE END

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